

family (see box). By 1766, he was the Esterházy's director of music, in control of an orchestra of more than 20 players—large for its time—and of an opera house at the newly built Esterháza palace. Technically he was only a senior palace servant, but he in fact enjoyed an enviable degree of independence. He was in effect permitted to use the court musicians as a testbed for his compositions and could, as he later said, “be as bold as I pleased.” His only significant constraint was the need to write many pieces for the baryton (a now extinct instrument related to the cello), which Prince Nikolaus Esterházy liked to play.



BARYTON, c. 1720

At the request of his employer, Haydn composed around 200 pieces (mostly trios) for the baryton, an instrument that had both plucked and bowed strings.

Classical innovation